Problem Statement 1

Black Cultural Centre for Nova Scotia

Current State

Black history resources in Canada are spread across museums, archives, libraries, universities, governments, community organizations, digital repositories and private collections. These sources use different catalogues, metadata, terminology and access rules. Users often need to know which institution to search before they begin and may not know what exists, where it is held, whether it is digitized or how related records connect. BCCNS wants to provide a trusted national discovery point that makes this distributed landscape easier to navigate without moving or duplicating every collection.

The Gap & Desired Outcome:

THE GAP: There is no simple, trusted discovery layer that connects Black history resources across institutions while preserving the ownership and authority of the original source. Metadata is inconsistent, many collections are only partly digitized, and useful information may be buried in finding aids, PDFs, websites, spreadsheets or local databases. Manual aggregation would be difficult for a small organization to sustain.

DESIRED OUTCOME: Build a scalable proof of concept that can ingest or reference metadata from multiple sample sources, normalize it into a common structure, and let users search by people, places, communities, subjects, dates, institutions and resource type. Each result should identify the source institution, explain where and how the resource can be accessed, link to the authoritative record and preserve provenance. Any AI-assisted search must be grounded in source records and avoid invented information.

Problem Statement:

How might the Black Cultural Centre for Nova Scotia create a trusted, scalable national Black History Knowledge Hub that enables people to discover and navigate Black history resources held across museums, archives, libraries, universities, governments, community organizations and other collections throughout Canada, while preserving the ownership, attribution and authority of each source institution, directing users to where the material is actually held, and making fragmented information easier to find, understand and connect?

Proof of Concept FOCUS: Demonstrate a searchable experience using at least two or three sample data sources. The prototype could include a common metadata model, search and filtering, source links, institution or location views, relationship mapping and/or grounded natural-language search. It should index or reference third-party resources rather than copy complete collections.